



**THE VOICE EXPRESS**

*The Truth Takes Time.*

THE VOICE EXPRESS GAZETTE

# Labyarinth

GENDER

## Labyarinth

*The first instalment of Labyarinth — TVE's series on bodies, desire, and the structures that keep us ignorant of both. Using Netflix's 'Lust Stories' and R.E. Gross's 'Vagina Obscura' as entry points, an essay on what Indian society still refuses to say when it refuses to talk about sex.*

BY MOULI SHARMA

9 JULY 2024 · 5 MIN READ



ABOUT

# The Voice Express

*The Truth Takes Time.*

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**New Delhi, India**

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INDEPENDENT • VOLUNTEER-RUN

VOL. 18 • EST. 2022

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# F\*cking the Obscurity Out of the Vagina Obscura

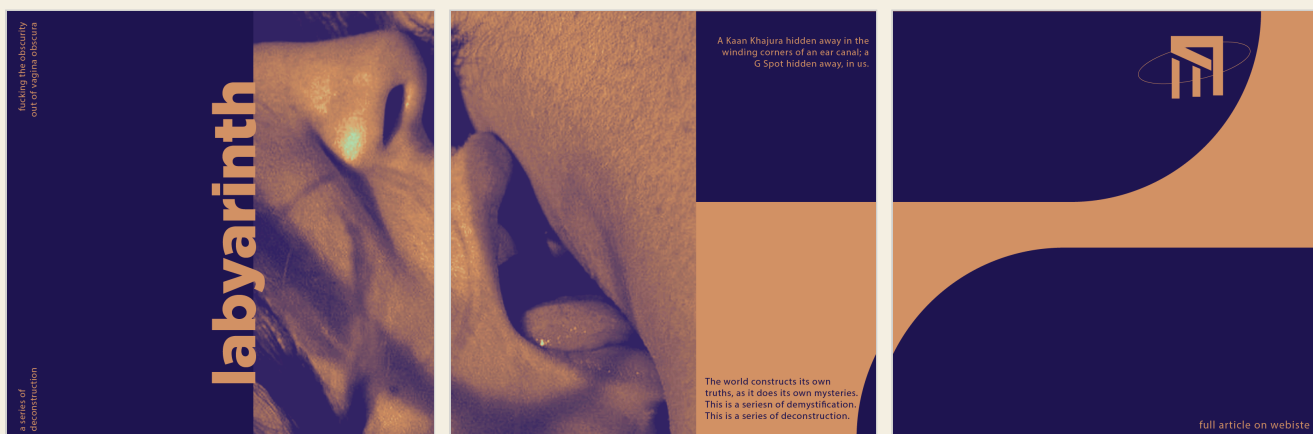
PILOT: A NEW SERIES

**F**ive years ago, after a well intentioned attempt at progressivism by multibillion dollar media conglomerate and part time streaming corporation Netflix came out in the form of a four part anthology film titled 'Lust Stories' to destigmatize sex and sexual desire in Indian society, the comedy group All India Bakchod released a promotional video on YouTube that will end up constituting part of this essay's vertebrae. Lust Stories was released in a social environment from whence India hasn't really progressed much further along in half a decade; indeed it is possible, it has regressed. Consider Uttarakhand's landmark Uniform Civil Code, which legally subjects live-in relationships between consenting adults in the state to government approval, or the crackdown of Hindu nationalist Bharatiya Janata Party along with the litany of its even more radical fringe sister-groups all over the country on 'Love Jihad.' So it is telling, that of the conversations that the film received praise and acclaim for starting, by far the one that received the most attention (and even more screen time) was that about none other than the great elusive female orgasm itself.

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Progress is a lady with a well worn funeral gown.

The AIB video in question was a series of mini sketches, for the most part reusing the group's well-tested 'Honest AIB' formula of speaking the unsociable truth in the cadence of expected social falsitudes - the same thing they'd been doing since the Diwali video went viral 10 year ago - and it was called 'The Truth About Lust'<sup>1</sup>. Jokes about the female orgasm, or lack thereof marked their presence (absence?) in the attendance register with glee. In one of these sketches, sex is a road and one's partner's climax is the destination. A young man in the driver's seat asks a passing woman for directions to 'a woman's pleasure point' followed by a sex inverted scene of a woman doing the same for her male partner. The humour lies in the contrast between the interactions - both described reasonably within the arranged marriage dominated diaspora of Indian marriage as 'clueless spouses' - a man left perplexed by seemingly over convoluted instructions<sup>2</sup> juxtaposed to a woman relieved to learn she would perhaps struggle to fail even if she tried.<sup>3</sup>



*Graphics by Shruti Patel*

Among the more typical connotations and Greek/Kafkaesque heritage of the labyrinth lies a definition of the word tucked into the tortuous folds of alternate dictionary meanings: an anatomical structure built of bends and twists and turns.

Two years ago a wonderful book called the Vagina Obscura (R. E. - wait for it - Gross) set out to solve this mystery, beginning her quest in - take a wild, wild, labyrinthian guess - Greece. A redrawing of women's bodies by women themselves, of finally knowing the parts of us for which we 'should've been ashamed'. A *Kaan Khajura* hidden away in the winding corners of an ear canal; a G Spot hidden away, in us.

Two years later still and the Vagina is little less obscure. Orgasm ratios are still in despair, husbands still cannot make their wives come and psychologists are bending over backwards to invent new psychological phalluses to fuck women over with now that Freud's have gone moldy and unpopular. The complexity of the female anatomical system has become deified, a mythological entity like Red Wine and Wrestling. And there is no clearer identifier of a myth that has outlived its utility, than when it starts getting in the way of desire.

*The world constructs its own truths, as it does its own mysteries. This is a series of demystification.*

*This is a series of deconstruction.*

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#### FOOTNOTES

<sup>1</sup>At least they didn't name it 'Honest Indian Lust'.

<sup>2</sup> Here's how the first of these conversations goes: "Excuse me, Miss, could you point me in the direction of the Woman's Pleasure Point?" "Oh, sure. It's pretty simple: go straight ahead from here, you'll get to the Vagina Toll point, where you'll have to get consent, a personality assessment etc to pass. After that you'll reach the Labia Minora gate - drive carefully there, it's really slippery. Then if you reach the Fallopian Flyover... you need to turn back, you've gone too far. And after turning back just drive around a bit, a little forward backward forward backward that's it that's it that's the spot right there right there keep it going ye oh yes oh - well if it rains you're there."

<sup>3</sup> Here's the second: "Excuse me, could you tell me where the Male Pleasure Point would be?" "There's a big building up ahead." "That's it?" "Yeah."

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Mouli Sharma is a journalist, freelance illustrator and writer from New Delhi, India. She is a published photojournalist & illustrator, having been featured in The Hindu College Gazette, & the quarterly Pink Disco. Mouli took over as the Editor of The Voice Express (<https://thevoiceexpress.github.io/e-mag/>) back in September 2023 & is currently working on a co-operative project with the Delhi Government on Media Cognizant Education for senior secondary school students.

Shruti Patel. Head of Design at TVE, Shruti is a beginner in the design field. She likes to work with illustrations, ux design and packaging, & (this part is not written by her) her eye is incomperable. She also writes sometimes.

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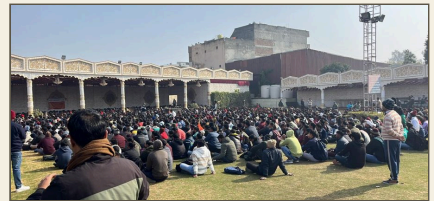
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